NEET-UG	JEE MAIN/ ADVANCED	CHINA'S GAOKAO
Medical entrance examination	Engineering entrance examination	University entrance examination
National Testing Agency	National Testing Agency	Centrally coordinated by the Ministry of Education and administered by individual provincial-level governments
2.3 million (2026)	1.7 million (2026)	13.35 million (2025)
Single test	Multi-test over different sessions	Multi-test over different sessions
Heavily dependent upon physical custody of papers in offline mode	Paper 1 is largely conducted as a computer-based test (CBT), so the risk shifts to software, network, proctoring and vendor integrity	Heavily dependent upon physical custody of papers in offline mode
Pen and paper/ OMR	JEE Main Paper 1 is CBT-only; Paper 2A mixes CBT with an offline drawing section	Pen and paper
Extensive outsourcing to private vendors	Same broad NTA vendor model	Mostly run by state-led local administration
Very high	Low	Almost nil

dates: JEE Main recorded fewer than 1.5 million appearances, CUET about 1.07 million, and the UPSC prelims around 58,000. But scale alone cannot explain the breach. China's national university entrance examination, Gaokao, had 13.3 million candidates in 2025, roughly six times NEET applicants, and is conducted under what is effectively military-grade security, with AI surveillance, signal jammers and swift, severe punishment for cheating.

The flaw in NEET is structural (see *NEET Versus...*). It is a one-shot test. A single exam, a single paper, decides everything. JEE, by contrast, has multiple layers—JEE Main, JEE Advanced and an eligibility filter of Class 12 marks. So, anyone trying to game it must breach the system at several points. It also runs as a computer-based test across multiple sessions with multiple sets of papers. The UPSC has its own filters of prelims, mains and an interview. Its scale then multiplies the danger for NEET. Because everyone sits the identical pen-and-paper test at the same hour, a breach in a single chain of custody taints the entire exam. Printing, storing and moving lakhs of sealed booklets to more than 5,400 centres—material that stays in motion for close to two weeks—creates handling point after handling point, each a fresh opportunity for leaks.

That is why most experts have pushed for shifting NEET to CBT. Former Union education secretary R. Subrahmanyam says he proposed the idea in 2018, "but the health ministry opposed it." There is resistance from the National Medical Commission (NMC) too. A CBT, they argue, could disadvantage rural and poor students, though Radhakrishnan Committee member Pankaj Bansal, co-founder of HR technology firm PeopleStrong, finds that argument hollow. "Rural and poor students are giving IIT-JEE." Most experts say the digital divide can be bridged through mock tests, sustained practice and the digital familiarity that near-ubiquitous smartphones have already brought to remote districts.

CBT also offers a layer of security that paper cannot. As Radhakrishnan explained in an interview on Doordarshan, since they do not have to be printed, questions can be selected



"The NTA does not have too many psychometric or deep experts to set question papers. The Educational Testing Service (ETS), which conducts GRE and TOEFL, has 600 researchers. We will have to build those things"

*— **Pankaj Bansal,** Co-founder, PeopleStrong, and Radhakrishnan Committee member*